

Internal Memo

To: Graeme Gillespie, Manager Public Health Programmes
From: David Curry, Project Leader, Paritutu Project
Copy to: Barry Borman, Annie Coughlan, Sally Gilbert, Deborah Read,
Subject: **Approval to undertake project analysing birth defect data**
Date: 28 September 2004 **File:** CD 55-46-2

The purpose of this memo is to seek your approval to undertake a project via Public Health Intelligence, to enter hard copy birth outcome data into the Birth Defects Register and to analyse this data to determine if there has been any significant increase in birth defects in the New Plymouth area that may be associated with dioxin exposures among Paritutu residents.

Background

The release of ESR's Interim Report on *A Study of 2,3,7,8-Tetrachlorodibenzo-p-dioxin (TCDD) Exposures in Paritutu, New Zealand Phase II: Serum Testing - An Interim Report to the New Zealand Ministry of Health* has stimulated community and media interest in the possible impacts of dioxin exposures for the Paritutu community. One issue being raised consistently by residents and the media is that of birth defects. The Holmes Show has advertised for people who are aware of birth defects in the Paritutu area to come forward and a former midwife has already publicly stated her belief that Paritutu had excessive numbers of birth defects.

Dr Patrick O'Connor undertook a study of birth defects (particularly neural tube defects) in the area in 2002 but was hampered by a lack of collated data. Dr O'Connor searched the local maternity hospital records to obtain the data for his study.

Health officials are aware that birth defect monitoring data from 1976 to 1986 was not entered onto an electronic register because of concerns about maintaining the security of the data and protecting the privacy of the (named) individuals. The completed forms (H661) are held in 30 to 40 boxes, estimated to contain around 500,000 birth outcome records. From 1981 to 1991 the forms were entered onto the database and in 1991 the H661 was discontinued with the birth defects data being recorded electronically from hospital admissions.

Comment

It is proposed that Public Health Intelligence contract the entry of the birth outcomes data (H661 forms) into the birth defects register and then undertake the analysis of the data for birth defects relating to New Plymouth and Paritutu.

It is estimated that this work, including the analysis, may be completed by February 2005, before the release of ESR's final serum dioxin study report. It is estimated that the cost for this will be no more than \$150,000, and this cost is primarily for contracting the data entry. There may also need to be some transfer of funding to PHI for backfilling staff.

Availability of Finance

The cost centre for this work would be 708179. Sufficient funding exists in the cost centre to enable the project to get underway. Once costs are clearer any additional funding necessary would be sought as part of the Project Paritutu funding bid.

Implications of proposal

If the project is approved, Barry Borman will:

- Organise the retrieval of the hard copy records
- Canvass data entry contractors and contract a suitable provider
- Manage the entry and verification of the data entry
- Analyse the data and report on the nature and prevalence of birth defects in the New Plymouth area, with a focus on Paritutu residents if possible, as quickly as possible and by February 2005 at the latest.

Once the PHI report is available, the release of the report will be managed as part of the communications strategy for the release of ESR's final report. (Current expectations are that the final ESR report will be released in mid-February.)

The database will be available for Health and other officials to examine the records for other birth defect data and trends. Dr Tuohy has previously indicated the data will be of interest for a number of reasons.

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Dr Borman has also indicated that PHI will be able to review Dr O'Connor's previous NTD report against the soil modelling ESR developed for the serum dioxin study and advise of the implications. Sally Gilbert will obtain the model from ESR and the addresses from Dr O'Connor to enable Barry to proceed with this.

Recommendation

It is recommended that you:

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1. **Note** that following the release of ESR's Interim Report, there has been significant media and community interest in birth defects among Paritutu residents;

YES/NO

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2. **Note** that the entry of the birth outcomes data into the birth defects register and the analysis of the data for birth defects relating to New Plymouth and Paritutu is estimated to cost up to \$150,000 and will come from the 708179 cost centre;

YES/NO

3. **Agree** that officials proceed with the proposal to contract the entry of the birth outcomes data (H661 forms) into the birth defects register and then undertake the analysis of the data for birth defects relating to New Plymouth and Paritutu as quickly as possible.

YES/NO

David Curry
Project Leader, Paritutu Project
Programmes Group, Public Health Directorate

Signed by Graeme Gillespie
Manager, Public Health Programmes

Date